

The Big Decisions of the Early Republic

Structured Academic Controversy + Art
Replaces the Gazette
About 1.5 to 2 weeks

The young country faced hard calls with no playbook. In

this project students grapple with three real decisions,

deliberate them in small groups, and then make an art

piece that shows the position they reached. It swaps the

solo writing of the old Gazette for talk, debate, and

visual making, with a defined job for every student.

The three decisions

Each one is chosen to also carry a second goal for the

year.

Decision (the question)	Sides	Also carries
A national bank? Should the U.S. create one big bank run with the government?	Hamilton (yes) vs. Jefferson (no)	Economics (E3.6-8.3)
Stay out of it? Should the U.S.	Stay neutral vs.	Foreign policy (C3.6-

stay neutral toward the
revolutions in France and Haiti?

take a side

8.5)

Safety or freedom? Should the
government limit speech to keep
the country safe (the Alien and
Sedition Acts)?

Protect the
nation vs.
protect free
speech

Rights vs. common
good (C4.6-8.4); a
sharp Now & Then
hook

The National Bank decision is built out in full on the

next sheets as your model. The other two follow the

same shape. Short briefs and the both-sides claims for

them are at the bottom of this sheet.

Why this fits where it sits

- It lands right after the SCOTUS debate,

which is a win or lose argument. This is the

opposite muscle: deliberation (talking to

understand, not to beat the other side), which

ends in your own honest position.

- Structured Academic Controversy forces

every student to argue both sides, which is exactly

what the discussion standard asks for.

- The art finish gives your varied learners

many ways to show the same thinking.

Standards

SSS3.6-8.1 (deliberate, analyze multiple viewpoints) ·

SSS1.6-8.1 (weigh evidence) · E3.6-8.3 (the bank, taxes,

currency) · C3.6-8.5 (early foreign policy) · C4.6-8.4

(rights vs. the common good) · H2.6-8.5 (people and

movements shape the era) · H4.6-8.3 (the Now & Then

tie).

Pacing at a glance

1.Day 1: Launch and the first decision (the

Bank). Read the brief, prep both sides.

2.Day 2: Run the Bank as a Structured

Academic Controversy. Reach group positions.

3. Day 3 to 4: Repeat the cycle with the

other two decisions (faster now that students know

the moves).

4. Day 5 to 7: Students build their art piece

from the choice menu, with a Then & Now panel.

5.Day 8: Fishbowl seminar on the big

question, then a gallery walk of the art.

The other two decisions (short briefs)

Foreign policy

Stay out of it? France and Haiti were both in revolution. France had helped us win our own. In Haiti, enslaved people freed themselves and built a new nation.

Stay neutral: We are young and weak. Neutral, meaning we do not take a side, keeps us safe and lets us grow.

Take a side: We owe France. And if we believe all people are created equal, can we ignore Haiti?

Safety vs. freedom

The Alien and Sedition Acts. During a war scare with France, Congress

passed laws that made it easier to remove immigrants and to punish people who printed harsh criticism of the government. Sedition means stirring up rebellion against the government.

Protect the nation: In dangerous times the country has to defend itself.

Protect free speech: The First Amendment protects speech and the press. These laws were used to jail newspaper editors who disagreed.

The Big Decisions — Teacher Guide — Mr. B's Social

Studies

Structured Academic Controversy

Teams of four (two pairs) About 30 minutes per decision

Work in a team of four. Your team splits into two pairs. One pair takes the YES side, the other takes the NO side. Here is the order.

1. **Prep (both pairs).** Read the brief. With your partner, find two or three strong reasons for your side.
2. **YES presents.** The NO pair listens and takes notes. Then the NO pair restates the YES pair's best point in their own words. (This proves you really listened.)
3. **NO presents.** Now the YES pair restates the NO pair's best point.
4. **Switch sides.** Each pair argues the other side. This is the most important step. You cannot judge a decision until you can argue both sides.
5. **Drop the roles.** As a four, talk freely and reach your own group position. You may agree, or you may agree to disagree and say where.
6. **Your stance.** On your own, write the position you personally landed on. You will use this for your art piece.

Team roles (everyone has a job)

Lead Speaker Says your side's reasons out loud. Speaks clearly and slowly.

Evidence Keeper Holds the brief and points to the exact facts that back up each reason.

Summarizer Restates the other side's best point. This is the listening job.

Recorder / Sketcher Writes the team's final position, or sketches the key arguments. A great fit if you think in pictures.

Talk moves to keep handy

- "I hear you saying . . . , and I would add . . ."
- "What is your evidence for that?"
- "I see it differently because . . ."
- "I changed my mind a little when . . ."

Should the U.S. Create a National Bank?

The year is 1790 Hamilton vs. Jefferson

The situation

The country was new and broke. It owed a huge debt (money it had borrowed) from the Revolution. Alexander Hamilton, the Treasury Secretary (the person in charge of the country's money), had a plan. He wanted a national bank: one large bank, run together with the government, to hold the country's money, help pay the debt, and lend to businesses. Thomas Jefferson and James Madison thought it was a dangerous idea. President Washington had to decide.

The big question: How much power should the national government have over money and the economy (everything people make, sell, and trade)?

Yes, build it (Hamilton)

- A national bank makes our money stronger and trusted, so the country can borrow and pay its debt.
- It lends to businesses, which grows trade and jobs.
- The Constitution lets Congress do what is "necessary and proper" to run the country. A bank is necessary.

No, do not (Jefferson)

- The Constitution never says the government can make a bank. If it does not say so, the government cannot do it.
- A bank helps rich merchants and city investors, not regular farmers.
- It puts too much money power in too few hands.

Money words to use

debt (*money you owe*) · **credit** (*trust that you will be paid back*) · **currency** (*the money a country uses*) · **tariff** (*a tax on goods coming from other countries*) · **economy** (*everything people make, sell, and trade*)

Your job

- Prep your assigned side. Find two or three reasons above and put them in your own words.
- Then argue the other side too.
- Land on your own stance, and get ready to make your art piece.

Then & Now

We still argue about how much the government should control money and the economy today. Find one current example for your Bellringer log.

Decision 1: The National Bank — Mr. B's Social Studies

Support Version

Decision 1

A National Bank: Yes or No?

The year is 1790

What is going on

The new country owed a lot of money. This is called **debt** (*money you owe*). Alexander Hamilton had a plan. He wanted a **national bank**: one big bank, run with the government, to hold the country's money and help pay the debt. Thomas Jefferson said no. President Washington had to choose.

Big question: How much power should the government have over money?

Yes (Hamilton)

- A bank makes our money strong.
- It helps the country pay its debt.

- It lends money so businesses can grow.

No (Jefferson)

- The Constitution does not say we can make a bank.
- A bank helps rich people, not farmers.
- It gives too few people too much power.

Pick a side with a stem

- I think the U.S. should _____ make a bank.
- My best reason is _____.
- The other side would say _____.

Then & Now

People today still argue about the government and money. Can you think of one example from the news?

Decision 1 (Support) — Mr. B's Social Studies

Your Project

Show Where You Stand

Pick oneSame rubric for every choice

Choose one way to show the position you reached on one of the three decisions. Whatever you pick, you must show your stance, back it with real history, show you understand the other side, and add a Then & Now connection.

Political cartoon

Draw

A period style cartoon that takes a side on the decision. Use symbols and a caption.

Campaign poster or buttons

Design

A poster, slogan, and button set supporting your position or a leader who held it.

Trading cards

Illustrate

Cards for the figures in the debate, with their side and their best argument.

Letter to the editor or comic

Write + draw

A short illustrated letter or a comic strip making your case to readers of the time.

Rubric (20 points)

What we score	4 — Exemplary	3 — Proficient	2 — Progressing	1 — Beginning
Stance	Clear, bold position a viewer gets at once	Clear position	Position is unclear	No position
Historical evidence	Two or more real facts from the decision used well	One real fact used	A fact is hinted at	No history
Other side	Shows real understanding of the opposing view	Names the other side	Mentions it vaguely	Missing
Then & Now	A sharp tie to a current issue	A tie to today	A weak tie	Missing
Craft	Neat, clear, and	Clear and	Rushed in places	Hard to follow

shows real effort complete

Support option: any student may record a 60 second spoken explanation of their piece in place of written text.

Show Where You Stand — Project Menu & Rubric — Mr. B's Social Studies